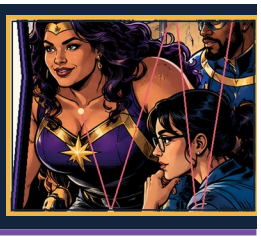
FIVE-STEP MICRO-ESCAPE DESIGN CANVAS

An editable worksheet for one practice-worthy decision.



Start small. Complete the steps in order, then revisit earlier choices when a test reveals a problem.

01 FIND THE PERFORMANCE GAP

Observed difficulty: What should happen, what happens instead, and what evidence suggests why?

02 MAKE SUCCESS OBSERVABLE

Given [situation/materials], learners will [observable action] to [measurable standard].

03 CHOOSE MECHANIC + STORY

Which player action requires the target thinking? What role, problem, and stakes give that action purpose?

04 BUILD THE CHALLENGE

What evidence, constraints, artifacts, and intended answer will you prototype and test?

05 DESIGN FEEDBACK + TRANSFER

How can players check/learn why, get hints, recover, and use the skill in a new situation?

DELIVERABLE A performance need, success criteria, playable concept, tested prototype, and feedback plan.

PUZZLE BLUEPRINT / PROTOTYPE WORKSHEET

Keep the learning action separate from its reward. Make a small packet, test it, and revise before adding polish.

MAP THE ACTUAL PLAYER EXPERIENCE

Briefing: What is the player's role, problem, and goal?

Inputs: Which clues, reference criteria, or artifacts do they receive?

Action: What must they decide, sort, assemble, or verify?

Answer / rationale: What solution follows from the supplied evidence?

Progress / reveal: What satisfying reward follows success? Could a player earn it without using the target skill?

Feedback / rationale: How will players know they are right and understand the reasoning?

Hints / recovery: What happens when they stall or run out of time?

Transfer: What new scenario or question will reveal independent understanding?

SKETCH THE CHALLENGE LOOP

CHALLENGE	ACTION	REWARD
A problem with meaningful stakes	A decision requiring the target skill	Clear resolution and useful feedback

Challenge–Action–Reward lens: Rachel Arpin (ATD, 2023). An earned reward should follow, not replace, a decision that practices the target skill.

AI ART ATTRIBUTION Selected character artwork was generated with OpenAI image-generation tools and adapted for this resource. AI-assisted text drafting was reviewed and edited by the author.